



Trigger Tracker

Understand and manage your triggers

What are Triggers?

Anxiety triggers are specific situations, thoughts, feelings, places, or people that can cause or worsen anxiety symptoms. They are highly personal and can vary greatly from one individual to another. Recognising your triggers is a crucial step in managing anxiety effectively. When you're aware of what sets off your anxiety, you can develop strategies to cope with, avoid, or reframe these situations.

Common Categories of Triggers

Situational Triggers

- **Specific Places:** Crowded places, public transportation, heights, enclosed spaces.
- **Social Events:** Parties, meetings, public speaking, networking events.
- **Performance Demands:** Exams, job interviews, deadlines, athletic competitions.
- **Unexpected Events:** Sudden noises, arguments, accidents.

Internal Triggers

- **Physical Sensations:** Heart palpitations, shortness of breath, dizziness, fatigue.
- **Emotions:** Fear, sadness, anger, guilt, shame.
- **Thoughts:** Negative self-talk, catastrophic thinking, worries about the future, intrusive thoughts.
- **Memories:** Past traumatic events, embarrassing moments.

The Impact of Unmanaged Triggers

When anxiety triggers are not addressed, they can lead to a cycle of avoidance. You might start to steer clear of situations that make you anxious, which can limit your life experiences and opportunities. Over time, this avoidance can reinforce the fear associated with the trigger, making it even harder to face. This can impact your relationships, career, and overall quality of life. Moreover, chronic anxiety can have physical health consequences.

Activity: Start Your Trigger Tracker

To effectively manage your anxiety, it's important to become a detective of your own experiences. This activity will help you identify and understand your personal triggers.

Instructions:

For the next week, keep a "Trigger Tracker" journal. Each time you notice yourself experiencing a significant level of anxiety or a panic attack, take a moment to record the following:

1. **Date and Time:** When did the anxiety occur?
2. **The Situation:** Where were you? Who were you with? What were you doing?
3. **Your Thoughts:** What was going through your mind just before and during the anxiety?
4. **Your Feelings:** What emotions did you experience (e.g., fear, worry, sadness)?
5. **Physical Sensations:** What did you feel in your body (e.g., racing heart, tight chest, sweating)?
6. **The Trigger (Hypothesis):** Based on the above, what do you think might have triggered your anxiety?

Example Entry:

- **Date/Time:** October 26th, 10:00 AM
- **Situation:** In a busy supermarket checkout line.
- **Thoughts:** "Everyone is staring at me. I need to get out of here. I can't breathe."
- **Feelings:** Panic, overwhelm.
- **Physical Sensations:** Heart pounding, dizziness, feeling hot.
- **Trigger Hypothesis:** Crowded public space, feeling observed.

Next Steps

Once you have a week's worth of entries, review your Trigger Tracker. Look for patterns and recurring triggers. Understanding these patterns is the first step toward developing personalised coping strategies. You might find it helpful to discuss your findings with a therapist or counselor, who can guide you in creating an effective management plan.